

**MYSTERY
SHOPPING
ASSESSMENT
2026 Q2
REPORT**

BACKGROUND

A 2024 study revealed an HIV prevalence of 27% among MSM and 54% among transwoman respectively. This high prevalence is associated with reduced accessing of health services by MSM, trans persons and other key populations due to high levels of stigma and discrimination.

The experiences of discrimination are undergirded by a legal system which criminalizes consensual same-sex intimacy between adults and fails to adequately and comprehensively protect MSM, trans persons, PLHIV and other key populations from all forms of discrimination. The UNAIDS societal enabler 10-10-10 targets will not be met in the context of Jamaica, unless the current legal system undergoes reform.

These experiences also result in a high level of internal stigma among PLHIV. In the People Living with HIV Stigma Index Jamaica published in 2020, more than half (53%) of PLHIV reported feeling guilty, ashamed, worthless, and/or dirty, 74% noting that they find it difficult to tell others of their HIV status, while 81% reported that they hide their HIV status from others.

The EFAF-commissioned 2024 LGBTQ+ Jamaican Needs Assessment Survey, only 16% of LGBTQ+ Jamaicans feeling safe living in Jamaican with the level safety experienced being different based on the setting, based on the Needs Assessment. Only 29% of LGBTQ+ Jamaicans deem public spaces as safe, 33% faith-based spaces, while 43% of LGBTQ+ people deem health spaces as safe or very safe. Additionally, more often than not, MSM and trans persons were not comfortable expressing their sexual orientation and gender identity in public health spaces.

Since 2019, EFAF has undertaken mystery shopping exercises across health facilities island-wide. Based on the reports we have received, there has been improvement in service delivery at these facilities, however, continued engagement of healthcare facilities is necessary to ensure that there is continued improvement of service delivery to key populations.

The Q1 2026 Reports focused on eight (8) facilities in Southern and Southeast health regions. This report assesses (7) facilities in Western and Northeast health regions.

METHODOLOGY

Selection of Sites

Using the Ministry of Health and Wellness website, eight (8) health facilities under the jurisdiction of the Western and Northeast Health Authority that offer free HIV prevention and treatment services were selected for assessment. Contact was then made with Shatha Richards, Enabling Environment and Human Rights Officer at the Ministry of Health & Wellness to inform the selected health facilities that they were selected for assessment.

Recruitment Strategy

Mystery Shoppers recruited for the Q1 assessments were re-engaged for the Q2 assessment, with a few new additions who were not able to participate initially.

Training

An online training of mystery shoppers was executed on June 21, 2026, with fourteen (14) participants. The training included basic information about HIV, protocol for an HIV test, any MOHW specific HIV testing rules, and examples of what a high-quality testing experience would include. Mystery shoppers were instructed to be honest about their sexual behaviours during their visits and to avoid creating false personas.

SITE VISITS

Pre-Visit Procedure

Before mystery shopping commenced, the Programmes and Advocacy Manager determined which site the mystery shoppers would visit. Each participant was assigned no more than three (3) treatment sites to conduct assessments from July 3 to 24, 2026.

All testing site was shopped at least three times by different mystery shoppers on different days and times. Shoppers completed the validated site assessment survey immediately after the visit. The assessment survey collected information on the duration of the visit, the clinic environment, and how well privacy and confidentiality were maintained. Shoppers also evaluated the providers' discussions regarding relationship context, testing and counselling assessment, safer sex recommendations, and PrEP-related discussions.

At the end of each assessment survey, shoppers were given the opportunity to provide an overall qualitative impression of their experience at the site. These open text fields enabled the shopper to describe how they felt about the site and the provider; anything notable that had occurred over the course of the visit, be it positive or negative; and any other information deemed pertinent to the experience that was not already captured by the quantitative assessment.

RESULTS

Fourteen (14) mystery shoppers completed assessments during this exercise, conducting a total of twenty-four (24) visits across seven (7) distinct facilities. Of the fourteen shoppers, twelve (12) were assigned male at birth and two (2) were assigned female at birth. Of those assigned male, two (2) identified as cisgender gay men, two (2) identified as cisgender bisexual men, five (5) identified as trans women and three (3) identified as being non-binary/gender non-conforming. Between the two persons assigned female, one identified as lesbian and the other identified as straight. Concerning age distribution, the ages of the shoppers fell within the following bands: 18–24 (n=4), 25–34 (n=3), 35–44 (n=5), 45–54 (n=1) and 55–64 (n=1). Using a scale of one to five with one being not comfortable at all and five meaning extremely comfortable, mystery shoppers gave facilities in the Western and Northeast region an overall average comfort score of 3.29 out of 5, just above "somewhat comfortable" on the scale. This similar to the 3.25 rating given to facilities in the Southern and Southeast region, suggesting the experiences may be universal across health regions. Chart 1 shows the average comfort rating for each facility relative to the overall average. Three facilities were scored above average and one was at average score.



Chart 1

At each facility, five categories of service providers were assessed for satisfactory treatment – security guards, administrative clerks, nurses, doctors and student doctors. The shoppers were invited to rate the experience with one being “very dissatisfied” and five being “very satisfied.” On average, each category of service provider scored between neutral and satisfactory, with nurses having an average score of 4.04 as the highest rated service providers and student doctors with the lowest rating of 3.46. Chart 2 shows the comparative averages.

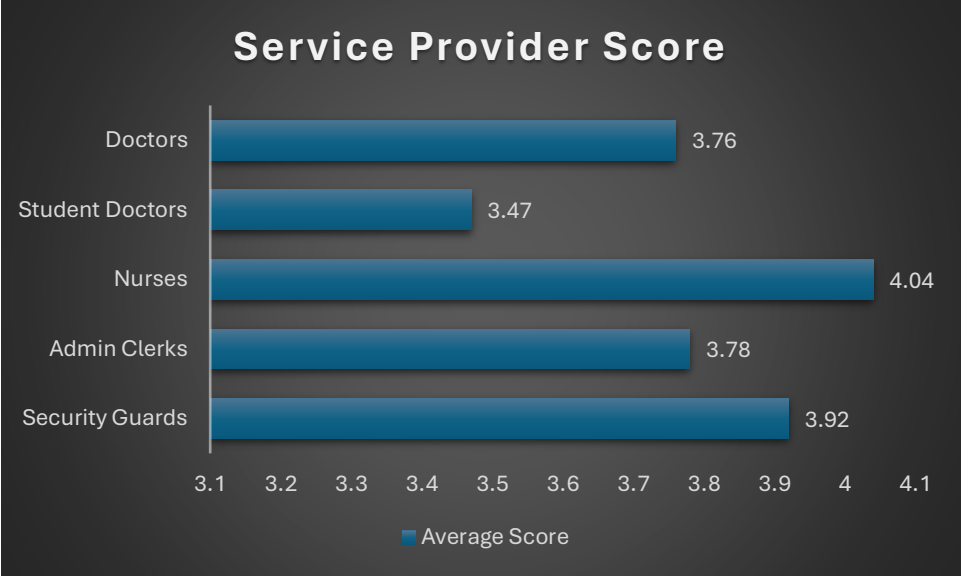


Chart 2

The experience of shoppers at each facility is explored in more detail below.

Falmouth Public General Hospital

The Falmouth Public General Hospital was assessed four (4) times by a cisgender gay man, a cisgender bisexual man, a cisgender lesbian woman and a non-binary male person. The non-binary person went for HIV testing and the other three accessed general health services. Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility, ranged from somewhat comfortable to extremely comfortable, for an average rating of 3.75, above the average of all facilities assessed.

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, the shoppers felt this was generally easy, with one person being neutral. All shoppers rated the staff as being professional or organized, however the gay man noted that customer service could be improved. Similarly, on the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, most shoppers felt the staff was respectful, with the lesbian woman noting there was room for improvement.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 4.25/5 (satisfied). For the admin clerk, the average was also 4.25, with one shopper being dissatisfied with the experience. Notably, this shopper is the gay man who recommended improvements. For the nurse, the average score was 4 (satisfied), for the doctor the average score was 3.67 (neutral - satisfied) and for the student doctor, the average score was 3.33 (neutral). Only the three (3) shoppers who went for general health services were seen by a doctor or student doctor. No unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff.

The shoppers mostly agree that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality (one shopper was neutral); none felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory; none felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them and none observed others being treated poorly. All shoppers gave positive feedback on their experience with frontline workers.

Overall, the shoppers were either neutral or positive in their assessment of the facility, with all indicating they would recommend the facility to another community member. The only recommendations were to reduce waiting times and service providers being more friendly.

Lucea Reproductive Health Centre

The Lucea Reproductive Health Centre was assessed three (3) times by two transgender women and a non-binary male person. One of the trans women and the non-binary person went for HIV/STI testing and the other trans woman accessed general health services. Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility, ranged from somewhat comfortable to extremely comfortable, for an average rating of 4.33, above the average of all facilities assessed.

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, two of the shoppers were neutral and one shopper felt it was very easy. All shoppers rated the staff as being professional. On the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, two shoppers felt the staff was respectful and one was neutral, as the doctor shared with one of the trans women shoppers that the facility did not have space to facilitate trans people yet.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 4.33/5 (satisfied). For the admin clerk, the average was also 4.33. For the nurse, the average score was a perfect score of 5, for the doctor the average score was also 5 and for the student doctor, the average score was 4.5. Only two (2) shoppers were seen by a doctor or student doctor. No unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff.

The shoppers all agree that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality; none felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory; and none felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them. However, two shoppers noted that they saw others being treated poorly, and one specifically shared that saw an elderly person being treated poorly. All shoppers gave positive feedback on their experience with frontline workers.

Overall, the shoppers were either neutral or positive in their assessment of the facility, with two indicating they would recommend the facility to another community member and one shopper, a trans woman, only saying maybe. She noted that there was homophobia within the facility, likely from other service users. The only recommendation made by the shoppers was to reduce waiting times.

Savanna-La-Mar Public General Hospital

The Savanna-La-Mar Public General Hospital was assessed four (4) times by a cisgender gay man, two transgender women and a non-binary male person. The gay man and one of the trans women went for general health services, the other trans woman went for PrEP services and the non-binary person went for HIV/STI testing. Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility, ranged from not so comfortable to very comfortable, for an average rating of 3.25, aligning with the average of all facilities assessed.

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, the shopper had varying experiences, with the gay man and one of the trans women finding it either difficult or very difficult while the other trans woman and non-binary person found it either easy or very easy. Notably, the gay man who had the difficulty and the trans woman who did not, did their assessments within an hour of each other. While the shoppers noted that the administrative staff were professional, in one instance, there was no customer service personnel available. On the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, three shoppers felt the staff were respectful and one was neutral, reporting that he noticed negative attitudes from the staff.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 4/5 (satisfied). For the admin clerk, the average was also 4.33. For the nurse, the average score was 4.5 (satisfied – very satisfied), for the doctor the average score was 3 (neutral) and for the student doctor, the singular score was 3. Only three (3) shoppers engaged an admin clerk and only two were seen by a doctor. No unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff, however it was noted that the doctor who attended one of the trans women who went for a general health check was told that she should not come to the hospital for those matters – “foolishness” – but should go to the health centre.

Only one shopper felt that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality, the others were either neutral or disagreed. None felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory; and none felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them. However, three shoppers noted that they saw others being treated poorly/differently. When assessing their experience with frontline workers, three of the shoppers noted areas for improvement. In one instance, a porter was deemed disrespectful, another suggested that the security could improve their communication skills and a third felt that the customer service rep could be more attentive.

Overall, the shoppers were positive in their assessment of the facility, however only two indicated they would recommend the facility to another community

member. For the other two shoppers, one trans woman said maybe because she was not sure her good experience would be the experience of another queer person and the other trans woman felt dissuaded by the doctor referring to her getting a general check-up as foolishness, and as such would not recommend the facility to another person. The recommendations made by the shoppers were to reduce waiting times and improve customer service.

St. James Type 5 Health Centre

The St. James Type 5 Health Centre was assessed four (4) times by a cisgender gay man, a cisgender straight woman and two transgender women. They all went for general health services. Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility, ranged from not so comfortable to very comfortable, for an average rating of 2.75, lower than the average of all facilities assessed.

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, no shopper found this easy, with the straight woman and one of the trans women being neutral in their assessment while the gay man and other trans woman found it either difficult or very difficult. While the shoppers noted that the administrative staff were professional, in one instance, a trans woman was being stared at uncomfortably by the security guard. On the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, two shoppers felt the staff were respectful and two were neutral.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 3.25/5 (neutral). For the admin clerk, the average was also 3.75 (neutral – satisfied). For the nurse, the average score was 3.5 (neutral – satisfied), for the doctor the average score was 4 (satisfied) and for the student doctor, the average score was 3.33. Only three (3) shoppers were seen by a student doctor. No unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff.

Three shoppers felt that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality, while one of the trans women was neutral on the matter. None felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory; and none felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them. However, two shoppers noted that they saw others being treated poorly/differently. When assessing their experience with frontline workers, three of the shoppers reported a positive experience, but one shopper did not like the experience – but did not articulate a clear reason.

Overall, the shoppers were generally positive in their assessment of the facility, however only two indicated they would recommend the facility to another community member. For the other two trans women shoppers who said maybe, one indicated she was not sure her good experience would be the experience of another queer person and the other trans woman was the shopper who generally did not like the staff but had no explicit reason. The recommendations made by the shoppers were to reduce waiting times.

Port Antonio Health Centre

The Port Antonio Health Centre was assessed three (3) times by a cisgender bisexual man, a transgender woman and a non-binary male person. The trans woman and the bisexual man went for HIV/STI testing and the non-binary person accessed dental services. Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility, ranged from not so comfortable to extremely comfortable, for an average rating of 3.67, above the average of all facilities assessed.

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, the shoppers had divergent experiences with the bisexual man finding it very easy, the non-binary person finding it very difficult and the trans woman being neutral. Similarly, while neither the bisexual man or the trans woman felt that they were asked unrelated questions by the admin staff, the non-binary person was asked about their sexuality though they were accessing dental services. On the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, two shoppers felt the staff was respectful and one was neutral. The non-binary shopper indicated they perceived negative attitudes from the staff.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 3.67/5 (neutral - satisfied). For the admin clerk, the average was 4 (satisfied). For the nurse, the average score was 4.33, for the doctor the singular score was 5 and for the student doctor, the singular score was 4. Only one (1) shopper was seen by a doctor or student doctor. No unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff.

Two of the shoppers agreed that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality, with one being neutral. The non-binary shopper felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory, and the trans woman was neutral on the matter; and similarly, the non-binary shopper felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them, while the other two did not have that experience. The non-binary shopper noted that they saw others

being treated poorly. Two of the shoppers had positive experiences with the frontline workers, however the non-binary shopper experienced rudeness.

Overall, the two shoppers who accessed HIV services were positive in their assessment of the facility, with both indicating they would recommend the facility to another community member. However, the non-binary shopper who went for dental services had a negative experience and would not recommend as they noted rudeness from both the frontline staff and nurse. She noted that there was homophobia within the facility, likely from other service users. The recommendations made by the shoppers were to reduce waiting times, increase awareness of the needs of trans persons and to deal with the general attitude of staff members.

Port Maria Health Centre

The Port Antonio Health Centre was assessed three (3) times by a cisgender bisexual man, a transgender woman and a non-binary male person. The non-binary person and the bisexual man went for HIV/STI testing and the trans woman accessed general health services. Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility, ranged from not so comfortable to somewhat comfortable, for an average rating of 2.33, lower than the average of all facilities assessed.

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, the experiences of the shoppers skewed negatively with the bisexual man having a neutral rating while, the non-binary person and trans woman found it difficult. The bisexual man did not feel he were asked any unrelated questions by the admin staff, however the trans woman noted that they refused to call them by their surname as requested, insisting on using their deadname. On the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, two shoppers were neutral on the question, and the non-binary shopper did not feel respected. The trans woman was publicly deadnamed when their name was called by the admin staff, causing unwanted attention from other service users and the non-binary shopper reported being counselled by the doctor who was attempting to change their sexuality.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 2/5 (dissatisfied). For the admin clerk, the average was 3.33 (neutral). For the nurse, the average score was 3.67 (neutral - satisfied), for the doctor the average score was 3 and for the student doctor, the average score was also 3.

Only two (2) shoppers were seen by a doctor or student doctor. The non-binary shopper was asked unnecessary questions as part of the doctor's attempt at conversion.

Two of the shoppers did not agree that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality, with the bisexual man strongly agreeing that it did. The non-binary and trans woman shoppers felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory, and the bisexual man did not have that experience; and similarly, the non-binary shopper felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them, while the other two did not have that experience. The non-binary shopper noted that they saw others being treated poorly. Two of the shoppers had negative experiences with the frontline workers.

Overall, the final assessment by the three shoppers was negative to neutral, with each shopper having at least one negative experience with either a frontline worker or medical staff. None of the shoppers would outright recommend this facility, with only shopper saying they may recommend the facility. In 2022 when this site was last assessed, there were similar issues with a transgender shopper experiencing discrimination. All shoppers recommended training for staff to reduce the stigmatizing and discriminating attitudes.

St. Ann's Bay Health Centre

The St. Ann's Bay Health Centre was assessed three (3) times by two non-binary persons and a transgender woman. The trans woman went for HIV/STI testing and the two non-binary persons accessed general health services. Generally, the shoppers rating of comfort in the facility, ranged from not so comfortable to very comfortable, for an average rating of 3, slightly below the average of all facilities assessed.

On the question of the ease of getting assistance, two shoppers found getting assistance relatively easy while the third, the trans woman was neutral. Similarly, the trans woman felt that they were asked unrelated questions by the admin staff, specifically the security guard, however the other two found them to be professional. On the question of respect for sexual orientation and gender identity, while two shoppers felt the staff were neutral on the question and one felt respected, the two neutral respondents both shared a negative experience. The trans woman perceived negative attitudes from staff, and one non-binary person takes the general view that all persons, regardless of identity, are subjected to disrespect.

On the question of treatment received by the security, the average score was 2.67/5 (dissatisfied - neutral). For the admin clerk, the average was 3 (neutral). For the nurse, the average score was 3.33, for the doctor the average score was also 3.33 and for the student doctor, the average score was 3.33. No point of contact, on average, was ranked as satisfied and no point of contact received an individual score of 5 from any shopper. No unrelated questions were asked by the medical staff.

Two of the shoppers agreed that the services met their unique needs, taking into account their sexuality, with one being neutral. The trans woman shopper felt that the healthcare workers were being evidently discriminatory, while the other did not experience same. None of the shoppers felt the healthcare workers were forcing their beliefs on them. None of the shoppers saw others being treated poorly. Two of the shoppers had positive experiences with the frontline workers, however the trans woman shopper perceived a negative attitude from the security guard.

Overall, the shoppers have a mixed experience. The experience of the trans woman shopper was negatively impacted by the security guard and one of the non-binary shoppers felt the doctor was being too invasive. The other non-binary shopper had an overall positive experience. Consequently, only the shopper with the positive experience indicated they would recommend the facility to another community member, with the other indicating maybe. This represents a decline since the last assessment in 2022, with the facility receiving an overall better assessment. The recommendations made by the shoppers were to improve the facility with a water cooler, replace the security guard and change the doctor who was found to be invasive.

CONCLUSION

Mystery shopping assessment across healthcare facilities in the Western and Northeast Health regions revealed inconsistencies in the delivery of healthcare to members of the LGBTQ+ community. This is not dissimilar from the experiences in Southern and Southeast. The average comfort score across both assessments were similar: 3.25 in the Q1 report and 3.29 in this report.

Across 24 visits to 7 facilities, experiences varied, not only between sites but within the same facility depending on which staff member a patient encountered. Lucea Reproductive Health Centre was the strongest performer,

while Port Maria Health Centre and St Ann's Bay Health Centres recorded the most concerning interactions.

Similar to the previous assessment, transgender and non-binary shoppers were likelier to have challenges when accessing services. Some shoppers experienced deliberate deadnaming, uncomfortable stares and even attempts at conversion by healthcare providers. Unlike previous assessment, security guards are no longer the lowest rated category of staff, as they fall within middle. Student doctors now have the lowest rating among shoppers, on average.

While cisgender shoppers, by contrast, generally reported smoother experiences regardless of sexual orientation, more transgender shoppers are having positive experiences, as more often than not, a facility's score is affected by a singular shopper's negative experience – emphasizing the importance of consistency in service delivery.

In the cases of Port Maria & St. Ann's Bay Health Centres, there seems to be a general atmosphere of stigma and discrimination, which has pervaded the experience of nearly all the shoppers who assessed either facility. These issues exist at multiple service points, suggesting the need for a holistic intervention. By contrast, Lucea and Falmouth generally received positive assessments, suggesting a culture of tolerance. There may be value in having exchanges between the facility managers of these health facilities to maintain a consistent standard across all health regions.

Waiting times were flagged several times as issues for shoppers, even where the facility received an overall positive assessment. As a longstanding issue in service delivery, it demands targeted interventions and resources. Ultimately, the findings align with the Q1 assessment, reflecting a healthcare environment where LGBTQ+ patients can access services but are not guaranteed non-discriminatory services with consistency. Based on the experiences of the LGBTQ+ community across the selected health facilities, the following is being recommended:

- Implement mandatory LGBTQ+ inclusivity and gender identity training for all clinical and non-clinical staff across all facilities.
- Establish a formal, facility-wide policy requiring acceptance of patients' chosen names and stated pronouns in all interactions.
- Introduce anti-stigma training specifically addressing HIV and sexual health services to eliminate judgemental staff conduct.
- Strengthen accountability at all facilities through visible anti-discrimination commitments and accessible complaints mechanisms for LGBTQ+ patients.

- Conduct follow-up mystery shopping assessments at all facilities to measure progress, with an expanded pool of shoppers to ensure broader and more representative coverage.
- Through the Enabling Environment in Health and Client Services Division of MOHW, facility learning exchanges between facilities that perform well in the assessment and those that perform poorly, to encourage peer-to-peer learning.